Swiss Banking and Digital Assets

The State of Adoption, Bank Strategies and What Comes Next



BLOCKSTORIES

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00 Foreword

Switzerland offers one of the clearest views into how banks adopt digital assets.

Its institutions entered earlier, and across more types of banks, than in almost any other major financial market. As banks elsewhere now decide how to enter, Swiss institutions can show what happens after launch: which capabilities prove valuable, which operating models endure and what it takes to expand.

The country's head start is visible across the sector:

- Swissquote introduced Bitcoin trading in 2017, followed by private banks, cantonal banks and PostFinance.
- Sygnum and SEBA, now AMINA, received banking licences in 2019 and became regulated infrastructure partners to other institutions.
- Our mapping identifies more than 30 Swiss banks providing some form of cryptocurrency investment access.
- Their approaches range from largely outsourced offerings to hybrid models and internally controlled custody.

Over several months, we spoke with many of the executives and practitioners responsible for digital assets inside these institutions. We asked how their initial decisions were made, what proved harder than expected and how years of operating experience have changed their priorities.

Their answers reveal that Swiss banks did not follow a common playbook. Some entered to retain existing clients. Others sought new wealth, wanted to serve blockchain companies or viewed crypto as a starting point for broader changes in financial infrastructure. Their investment decisions reflect those different objectives.

This report distils those experiences into practical lessons for banks around the world: how to enter digital assets, which capabilities to own, where partnerships add value and how to expand once demand emerges.

It also examines the next test for Switzerland. The country established an early lead in crypto banking. Whether it can translate that experience into a similar position in digital money and tokenized finance remains an open question.

We hope you enjoy it.



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01 Key Insights

01

Switzerland's Early Lead Combined Regulatory Clarity With Real Client Demand

Technology-neutral regulation and direct access to FINMA reduced uncertainty before dedicated DLT legislation existed. That clarity met a competitive banking landscape under pressure to differentiate, plus early demand from blockchain companies, foundations and holders of crypto-generated wealth. Together, these conditions gave Swiss banks reasons to act earlier than peers elsewhere.

02

Switzerland's Lead Is Deep, but Concentrated

More than 30 Swiss banks now provide some form of crypto investment access, yet direct trading and custody remain absent from several major institutions and only five of 24 cantonal banks have launched. Switzerland's lead lies in the depth and variety of experience among early movers, not in market-wide adoption.

03

The First-Mover Opportunity in Crypto Access Has Largely Passed

Early entrants could use crypto to attract clients and assets that other banks would not accept. As major wealth managers globally add access, that window is narrowing. New launches will increasingly protect existing relationships rather than win crypto-native wealth, while differentiation shifts to lending, onchain investment products and broader banking services.

04

Crypto-Generated Wealth Offers Private Banks the Largest Upside

Basic access can meet occasional client demand, but the larger opportunity lies with clients whose wealth already exists onchain. Banks able to verify its origin, accept transfers and connect holdings to liquidity, lending, diversification and investment management can win broader relationships. The addressable market and resulting assets should not be assumed.

05

Swiss Banks Have Adopted Three Distinct Infrastructure Models

The market spans partner-led offerings, hybrid architectures combining internally controlled custody with outsourced execution, and more integrated platforms covering custody and trading. No model is inherently superior. Banks planning broader digital-asset services place greater value on operational control and the flexibility to add transfers, lending or tokenized assets without rebuilding their infrastructure.

06

Europe Is the Next Market for Switzerland's Digital-Asset Specialists

AMINA's Austrian MiCA authorisation and Sygnum's Liechtenstein CASP licence give them regulated access to a larger European market. Medium-sized banks remain natural buyers of integrated platforms, while larger institutions will source more selectively. To preserve their specialist edge, both are expanding beyond trading and custody into tokenized funds, onchain products, blockchain-based payments and institutional banking.

07

Crypto Funds Today's Capabilities While Tokenization Stays the Long-Term Bet

Trading and custody already answer visible client demand, giving banks a reason to fund infrastructure, controls and blockchain expertise today. Those capabilities can later support tokenized securities, collateral and settlement, but they do not guarantee adoption. Swiss banks will only increase their investment meaningfully once tokenization demonstrates clear operational gains and enough assets and counterparties participate to deliver them at scale.

08

The Swiss Franc Still Lacks a Stablecoin With Domestic Scale

The franc's appeal as a store of value has not produced enough transaction demand to cover the operating costs of a Swiss issuer, while low interest rates weaken reserve economics. The joint CHF stablecoin sandbox is therefore testing whether programmable payments can create repeatable use cases across banking and onchain markets.

How Switzerland Got Here

02

Switzerland's early adoption of digital assets grew out of a particular combination: an established international banking centre, an emerging community of crypto businesses and investors, and a regulator willing to clarify how existing law applied.

Together, these conditions created both commercial incentives and a workable basis for institutions considering entry. They also left considerable room for banks to choose different roles.



01

Switzerland's Banking Market Enabled Multiple Paths Into Digital Assets

Switzerland brought an unusually broad financial-services industry to this emerging market. International wealth managers operated alongside smaller private banks, cantonal banks and providers focused on online investing. Their customers, distribution and resources differed, creating opportunities to compete through the relationships and services each institution chose to pursue.

Digital assets offered several such opportunities. A private bank could seek wealth accumulated by crypto entrepreneurs. An online bank could expand its investment offering. A specialist provider could supply the technology or financial services needed by institutions entering the market.

These roles developed over time. Bitcoin Suisse, founded in 2013, was an early crypto-native provider of brokerage, custody and related financial services. Taurus, founded in 2018, represented a later institutional-infrastructure model, developing custody, tokenization and trading technology for regulated financial institutions. Their emergence meant that banks could increasingly draw on external expertise when building digital-asset offerings.

02

Crypto Businesses and Wealth Created New Banking Needs

The opportunity became tangible as Switzerland attracted blockchain projects and the people financing and building them. Ethereum's 2014 fundraising announcement described establishing its legal structure in Switzerland, an early example of the activity associated with the country's developing Crypto Valley.

Companies and foundations operating in the crypto ecosystem—including some that raised capital through token sales—still needed conventional banking services: accounts, conversions and payments to employees and suppliers. On the private side, entrepreneurs and investors could need help documenting the origins of their wealth, converting holdings and diversifying into traditional investments. These relationships created a different opportunity from selling Bitcoin to an existing banking customer.

Yet these prospective clients were not straightforward to serve. In September 2018, the Swiss Bankers Association linked the growth of blockchain companies to rising demand for corporate accounts, while highlighting money-laundering and due-diligence challenges. Its guidelines aimed to help banks assess such relationships within established KYC processes.

For banks willing to develop that expertise, the difficulty itself created an opportunity. Maerki Baumann's experience, examined later in this report, illustrates how serving clients that other institutions hesitated to accept could become a route into broader banking and wealth-management relationships.

03

Regulatory Clarity Made Participation More Practical

Serving those clients also required a workable interpretation of financial-market law. Switzerland initially addressed digital assets through existing rules, applying them based on an activity's economic function and risks. FINMA's February 2018 ICO guidelines made this more concrete by distinguishing payment, utility and asset tokens and indicating which rules could apply.

For prospective providers, published guidance and supervisory dialogue helped clarify the requirements before substantial investment, as Cornelia Stengel explains:



> FINMA's early token taxonomy gave projects a common language and made the regulatory consequences more predictable. Direct supervisory dialogue was particularly important for banks, because it allowed them to clarify licensing, custody and AML questions before committing substantial resources.
>
> **Cornelia Stengel,** Kellerhals Carrard

Banks could consequently develop crypto services before a dedicated DLT framework existed. Swissquote introduced Bitcoin trading in 2017. In August 2019, FINMA granted banking and securities-dealer licences to Sygnum and SEBA, now AMINA, bringing specialised providers within the banking framework.

Legislation then addressed questions that interpretation alone could not resolve. The DLT reforms, adopted in 2020 and implemented in 2021, established ledger-based securities, clarified crypto-asset segregation in insolvency and introduced a licence for DLT trading facilities. Together, these changes created legal foundations beyond cryptocurrency investment.



> Switzerland's real advantage was regulatory architecture, not light-touch regulation. Existing financial-market law continued to apply where the economic function and risks remained the same.
>
> **Cornelia Stengel,** Kellerhals Carrard

The following chapters examine the resulting choices: how a universal bank, private banks, retail institutions and digital-asset specialists have connected these capabilities to the clients they serve.

State of Adoption & Strategies

03

Swiss banks occupy very different positions in digital assets. Some focus on investment products or tokenization projects, while others have built trading, custody and broader banking services. Their choices reflect client demand, resources and strategic priorities.

This chapter compares those approaches across four segments, from UBS to the digital-asset specialists.

FOUR SEGMENTS

I. **Global Universal Bank**
UBS

II. **Domestic and Retail Banks**
Cantonal banks, Raiffeisen, PostFinance and direct banks

III. **Private Banks**
International wealth managers and specialist houses

IV. **Digital-Asset Banks**
Sygnum and AMINA



MARKET OVERVIEW

Who Offers What

Selected direct crypto services and digital-money initiatives at Switzerland's 15 largest banking institutions by 2025 total assets, as of September 2026

● LIVE ○ IN PREPARATION / PILOT — NO PUBLIC OFFERING IDENTIFIED

BANK	CUSTODY	DIRECT TRADING	CRYPTO LOANS	STAKING	STABLECOIN
UBS	—	—	● BITCOIN ETF AS COLLATERAL	—	○ CHF STABLECOIN SANDBOX ○ G7-CURRENCY CONSORTIUM
RAIFFEISEN	○ ANNOUNCED (SYGNUM)	○ ANNOUNCED (SYGNUM)	—	—	○ CHF STABLECOIN SANDBOX
Zürcher Kantonalbank	● FIREBLOCKS	● CRYPTO FINANCE	—	—	○ CHF STABLECOIN SANDBOX
PostFinance	● SYGNUM	● SYGNUM	—	● SYGNUM	○ CHF STABLECOIN SANDBOX ● USDC
Julius Bär	● AMINA	● AMINA	● DIRECT CRYPTO	—	—
MIGROS BANK	—	—	—	—	—
Luzerner Kantonalbank	● FIREBLOCKS	● WYDEN	● DIRECT CRYPTO	—	● USDC + USDT
BCV	—	—	—	—	○ CHF STABLECOIN SANDBOX
Basler Kantonalbank	—	—	—	—	—
St.Galler Kantonalbank	● AMINA	● AMINA	—	—	—
UBP	—	—	—	—	—
BEKB | BCBE	—	—	—	—	—
PICTET 1805	○ IN PREPARATION	○ IN PREPARATION	—	—	—
Aargauische Kantonalbank	—	—	—	—	—
EFG	—	—	—	—	—

ADOPTION FRAMEWORK

How The Different Segments Are Building In Digital Assets

Priorities vary, and there's no single path to adoption. Below is a high-level framework of where activity can be observed in the Swiss market.



This framework covers a curated selection of Swiss banks with active or publicly documented digital-asset initiatives and is not intended as an exhaustive market overview. Positions reflect our qualitative assessment of live crypto-service breadth and demonstrated deployment of tokenization and digital money. Announcements and isolated transactions do not establish recurring commercial adoption. Absence of identified activity does not establish inactivity.

ADOPTION FRAMEWORK

How The Different Segments Are Building In Digital Assets

Approaches differ within each segment, but shared business models reveal clear patterns in what drives their digital-asset strategies.

	01 Global Universal Bank	02 Domestic and Retail Banks	03 Private Banks
State Today	**Tokenization ahead of crypto access.** Tokenized bonds, structured products and a money-market fund are live, alongside pilots in tokenized deposits and wholesale settlement. Direct crypto trading and custody are not offered; exposure runs through ETFs, now accepted as Lombard collateral.	**Basic access, spreading unevenly.** Buy-and-hold trading and custody inside e-banking, mostly launched since 2023. Very few banks add transfers, savings plans, staking or lending, but most cantonal banks have yet to launch and basic access now offers little differentiation.	**Early start, uneven depth.** A small group of specialist houses accepts crypto transfers and offers lending, staking and banking for crypto companies. Others limit themselves to execution-only trading or crypto-linked products, and several large wealth managers offer no direct access at all.
Key Drivers of Digital Assets Strategy	**Building internal capabilities for long-term tokenization bet.** Live issuances and pilots develop expertise in digital assets infrastructure before adoption reaches scale. Being involved in multiple projects also builds the strategic network and helps identifying the use cases that can drive value for corporate and institutional clients.	**Keeping customers' investment activity.** Customers already buy crypto on exchanges and apps. Offering it in e-banking prevents outflows and keeps that activity inside the bank. It's therefore not only a defensive strategy, but also unlocks a new revenue stream.	**Winning wealth made in crypto.** Clients with crypto fortunes need a bank that can verify how the wealth arose, accept it and help diversify it. Core banking services and investment mandates carry the economics.
Typical Operating Model	**Settlement networks built in consortia.** Payment and securities-settlement networks are developed jointly with other banks, central banks, market infrastructures and technology providers. The bank tests tokenized deposits, stablecoins and central-bank money in parallel, since each network is only as useful as the counterparties that join it.	**Partner at launch, own custody later.** Most banks launch with a specialist provider covering custody and execution. The larger the bank and the further its offering scales, the more it considers bringing activities in-house, starting with custody, which underpins transfers, lending and future tokenized assets. Execution and liquidity usually remain with external providers.	**Buy the infrastructure, keep the client decision** Custody and execution come from specialist banks, technology vendors or the bank's existing outsourcer. Source-of-wealth assessment, relationship-manager expertise and credit decisions stay inside, because they determine which clients the bank can accept.
What's Next	**From issuance to repeatable, end-to-end workflows** Continued participation in joint projects spanning tokenized securities, digital money and settlement provides a practical route to expand internal infrastructure, connect with external networks and move from individual transactions towards repeatable operating capabilities.	**Selective depth beyond basic access.** Selective depth beyond basic access. External transfers spread where banks want to attract existing holdings, while selected larger providers take greater control of custody. Lending and staking remain concentrated, and digital-money work centres on banks with substantial payments or corporate-treasury franchises.	**More lending, selective onchain yield.** Established providers seek comfort with higher loan-to-value ratios and larger facilities, while the most deeply integrated banks explore curated onchain yield. Larger wealth managers apply tokenization to portfolio operations as the approved onchain investable universe expands.

UBS
Building Digital Assets Into a Global Bank

I.
G-SIB

BIGGEST MILESTONES

06 / 2021

PROJECT JURA: WCBDC SETTLEMENT

UBS participates in the BIS, SNB and Banque de France experiment testing tokenized securities settlement and EUR/CHF wholesale CBDC transactions.

02 / 2022

PROJECT HELVETIA PHASE II

UBS is one of five banks testing Swiss wholesale CBDC integration and settlement of tokenized assets.

11 / 2022

UBS ISSUES CHF 375 MILLION DIGITAL BOND

UBS issues a bond tradable and settleable across SIX Digital Exchange and traditional market infrastructure.

06 / 2023

UBS TOKENIZE GOES LIVE

First production issuance: CNH 200m digital structured notes for BOCI on Ethereum.

11 / 2023

FIRST CROSS-BORDER REPO WITH DIGITAL BOND

UBS, SBI and DBS execute and settle a live repo on a public blockchain under Project Guardian.

11 / 2024

UMINT LAUNCHES

UBS Asset Management launches its first tokenized fund, a USD money market fund on Ethereum.

DIGITAL CASH PILOT COMPLETED

Tokenized-deposit payments are tested in USD, CHF, EUR and CNY, including intragroup liquidity transfers.

09 / 2025

SWISS DEPOSIT TOKEN PAYMENT POC

UBS, PostFinance and Sygnum complete legally binding interbank payment with tokenized deposits on Ethereum.

11 / 2025

END-TO-END TOKENIZED FUND WORKFLOW

UBS Tokenize and DigiFT automate fund subscriptions and redemptions via Chainlink.

2026

BROADER DIGITAL MONEY ACTIVITY

UBS joins the CHF Stablecoin Sandbox, advances a global G7-currency consortium, tests cross-border stablecoin payments with Merge and participates in Swift Ledger.

In our view, UBS approaches digital assets from a different starting point than most Swiss banks. As a global systemically important bank, its choices have to account for multiple jurisdictions, regulatory regimes and businesses ranging from private banking to asset management and capital markets.

That complexity has made UBS cautious, but not inactive. For years, the bank drew a relatively clear line between cryptoassets, which it approached conservatively, and blockchain-based financial infrastructure, where it became an early participant. More recently, that distinction appears to be softening as UBS broadens its digital-asset activity beyond tokenization and infrastructure.

One Group. Four Divisions. One Swiss Universal Bank.

UBS's business model is central to understanding its approach. Its strategy centres on global wealth management and its universal bank in Switzerland, complemented by Asset Management and the Investment Bank. Global Wealth Management serves private wealth clients globally. Personal & Corporate Banking anchors the Swiss universal-bank model, serving private, corporate and institutional clients. Asset Management serves institutions, wholesale intermediaries and wealth-management clients.

The four divisions encounter digital assets from different angles. Global Wealth Management focuses on private-client investment and financing. Personal & Corporate Banking brings the perspective of Swiss private, corporate and institutional clients, including payments and deposits. Asset Management focuses on tokenized investment products and fund infrastructure, while the Investment Bank drives much of UBS's work on tokenized bonds, structured products and capital-markets infrastructure.

At the same time, UBS's activities point to an increasingly coordinated approach at Group level, particularly around infrastructure and external partnerships. Its initiatives span banks, market infrastructures, distribution partners, technology vendors and crypto-native firms. Shared infrastructure and relationships can therefore be reused across divisions rather than built separately.

Tokenization Was the Starting Point

Tokenized traditional assets offered UBS an early bridge into digital markets. Bonds, funds and structured products could be applied to activities the bank already understood: issuance, distribution, collateral, settlement and asset management.

UBS participated in Project Helvetia, issued a CHF-denominated digital bond in 2022 and subsequently used UBS Tokenize across structured products and capital-markets transactions. In Asia, it originated BOCI's tokenized notes and launched a tokenized warrant in Hong Kong. Under Project Guardian, UBS, SBI and DBS later completed a cross-border repo involving a natively issued digital bond.

Asset Management extended that work into funds. The launch of uMINT in 2024 brought tokenization into a conventional money-market product, while subsequent work with DigiFT and Chainlink focused on subscription and redemption workflows.

The focus is also beginning to broaden beyond issuance. In line with the wider market, UBS is exploring how tokenization could support more of the asset lifecycle, including distribution, servicing, collateral use and settlement.

Digital Money: Building Experience Across the Full Spectrum

As UBS broadens its work on tokenized assets, digital money becomes the other side of the equation: supporting both the settlement of onchain securities and new payment use cases, particularly for corporate and cross-border flows.

The bank appears to be exploring several forms in parallel. Digital Cash applies tokenized deposits to corporate and institutional payments. Projects such as Helvetia and Agorá examine how central-bank and commercial-bank money could operate in tokenized and cross-border markets. Stablecoin activity ranges from cross-border payment tests to participation in international and Swiss consortium initiatives.

So far, UBS's activities do not point to a single preferred model. Tokenized deposits, stablecoins and central-bank money are all being explored in parallel. That may reflect their different potential use cases, but also a market in which the eventual mix remains unsettled. Much of the work is still exploratory, focused on understanding demand and determining which models prove operationally and commercially viable.

UBS'DIGITAL MONEY INITIATIVES

Commercial Bank Money

UBS DIGITAL CASH
Multi-currency tokenized deposits for corporate payments and treasury.

SWISS DEPOSIT TOKEN POC
In collaboration with PostFinance and Sygnum.

SWIFT LEDGER
Pilot participant on Swift's blockchain ledger for tokenized deposits

Central Bank & Wholesale Money

PROJECT HELVETIA
SNB-BIS-led wholesale CBDC settlement for tokenized assets.

PROJECT AGORÁ
BIS-led cross-border wholesale payments initiative.

FNALITY
Founding investor alongside other global financial institutions.

Stablecoins

CHF STABLECOIN SANDBOX
CHF stablecoin testing with Sygnum, PostFinance, ZKB and others.

G7 STABLECOIN CONSORTIUM
Member alongside other major banks.

TEMPO
Design partner in payments blockchain.

MERGE
Cross-border payments PoC.

Crypto Is Moving Closer to the Core Bank

UBS has historically approached cryptoassets more cautiously. In 2021, then-CEO Ralph Hamers described crypto as an "untested asset category", and UBS did not actively offer direct access. Like other G-SIBs, the bank moved much faster on blockchain-based financial infrastructure than on crypto exposure itself.

The backdrop has since changed materially. Regulatory developments, particularly in the US, have brought crypto closer to traditional finance, while spot Bitcoin ETFs have made exposure easier to integrate into banking and wealth-management structures.

UBS has begun reflecting that shift in conventional banking products. Since 2026, selected Bitcoin ETFs can under certain conditions be pledged as collateral for Lombard lending, bringing crypto exposure into an established wealth-management use case.

Custody and trading could be a next step, but no broad offering has been publicly confirmed. If UBS does move in that direction, an initial rollout through its Swiss private-client business appears plausible. Institutional appetite for direct crypto services still appears relatively limited, while retail and wealth clients may provide the more immediate source of demand.

Building Through Consortia and Shared Market Infrastructure

Another recurring feature of UBS's activity is how often it works alongside other institutions rather than attempting to build new financial networks in isolation.

Helvetia, Agorá, Project Guardian, the global stablecoin initiative and the Swiss stablecoin sandbox all involve combinations of banks, central banks, market infrastructures, technology providers and public institutions. That collaborative approach also extends to crypto-native infrastructure providers. UBS and Nethermind recently completed two proofs of concept exploring how public Ethereum could meet operational and compliance requirements for regulated financial institutions.

All of this signals a pragmatic approach. Digital money and tokenized markets depend heavily on interoperability and distribution. A bank can build its own infrastructure, but its usefulness remains limited if counterparties, clients and other financial institutions operate on different rails.

This distinguishes UBS from institutions that have taken a more proprietary path. Société Générale's SG-FORGE provides a useful contrast, with a model centred more heavily on internally issued digital assets and dedicated infrastructure. UBS has so far leaned more toward shared infrastructure and industry-wide initiatives where network effects matter.

II.

MARKET SEGMENT 02

Domestic and Retail Banks

CASE STUDIES

Zürcher Kantonalbank
Luzerner Kantonalbank
PostFinance
Swissquote

Swiss Retail Banking: From Early Movers to Broader Access

Switzerland was an early market for crypto banking, but access through its everyday banks developed more gradually. Swissquote introduced Bitcoin trading in 2017; the first cantonal-bank offering followed in 2023. Since then, launches by regional and nationwide institutions have brought crypto into more of the country's established banking relationships.

The market is now entering a different phase. Banks considering an offering can draw on infrastructure and experience that their predecessors helped establish. This makes entry more accessible, particularly for institutions with limited specialist resources. Yet the expanding range of services conceals important differences in customer demand, management support and commercial ambition.

A Diverse Market with Strong Local Relationships

Switzerland's domestic banking landscape helps explain this pattern. Alongside UBS, it includes 24 cantonal banks, the cooperative Raiffeisen group, PostFinance, regional banks and digital investment platforms. These institutions compete for overlapping customers, but approach them through different relationships and business models.

The cantonal banks are independent institutions tied to Switzerland's constituent cantons. They combine regional roots and public ownership with commercial banking activities, but differ widely in scale and make their own product, technology and investment decisions. Crypto therefore spreads through individual launches and partnerships rather than a coordinated sector-wide rollout.

Outside that group, PostFinance brings a nationwide client base and a strong payments heritage, while Raiffeisen operates through a cooperative network. Digital platforms such as Swissquote and Yuh compete for investment activity without relying on the same regional relationships.

This structure creates several routes for adoption. A service can spread through a digital platform, become part of a cantonal bank's investment offering or reach multiple institutions through a shared provider. The number of banks launching consequently tells only part of the story: their distribution and customer reach matter too.

The Second Wave of Adoption

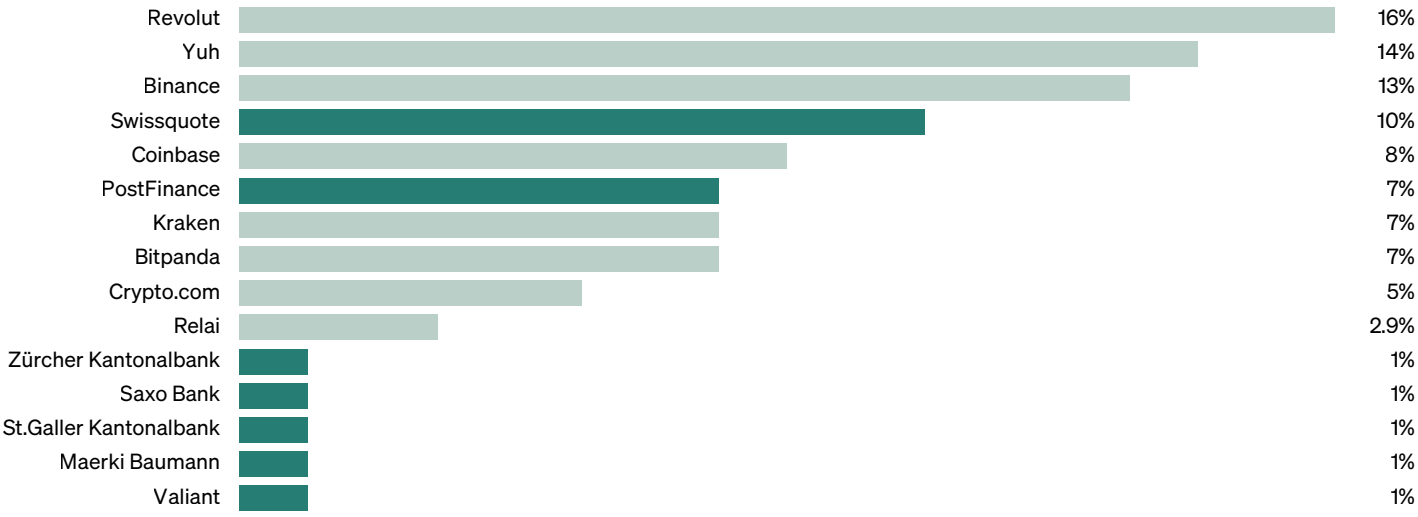
Swissquote's 2017 launch fitted its established role as an investment platform. Customers already used it to make their own decisions across different markets, making crypto a logical addition. For conventional retail banks, introducing the same asset class required accommodating it within broader customer relationships and more cautious product cultures.

The broader wave arrived in 2023–2024. Zuger Kantonalbank launched integrated trading and custody in October 2023, followed by St.Galler Kantonalbank with an initial offering for selected customers. PostFinance, LUKB and ZKB entered during 2024. Further launches, including BancaStato in July 2026, have continued to widen access.

These banks were entering a market their customers had already discovered. By early 2026, 18% of Swiss adults held cryptoassets, up from 11% in 2024, according to the representative HSLU/LUKB survey. Digital platforms nevertheless continued to lead reported provider usage. For established banks, the opportunity was partly to bring existing investment activity into their own channels.

MARKET SHARE

Where Swiss crypto holders invest



Source: HSLU Study "Kryptoanlagen in der Schweiz", June 2026 • n = 297

As more Swiss providers entered, the competitive question also changed. Customers seeking crypto access could increasingly choose another familiar banking brand. An institution remaining absent risked conceding investment activity to domestic competitors as well as international exchanges.

The accompanying market overview shows how differently banks have responded. Direct trading and custody do not necessarily include external transfers, continuous trading or access for every customer segment. These distinctions determine whether a bank can capture occasional purchases, receive existing holdings or support a broader investment relationship.

Similar Products, Different Commercial Objectives

Growing ownership gives banks a reason to examine crypto, but does not prescribe a single business case. Across the Swiss market, four motives help explain the different approaches.

COMMERCIAL MOTIVES

Four objectives, from defending to building

01

Retain investment activity

Enable existing customers to invest in crypto through their bank, keeping more activity within the relationship.

02

Attract investment assets

Attract holdings accumulated elsewhere by combining crypto with a broader investment and banking offering.

03

Protect banking partnerships

Extend services to other banks and defend the wider commercial relationships attached to them.

04

Develop future capabilities

Build expertise and infrastructure relevant to future products, payments and internal banking processes.

A bank can pursue several of these objectives, but their relative importance determines where further investment makes sense. Capturing new purchases places different demands on an offering from attracting substantial existing holdings. Providing infrastructure to other banks introduces another set of requirements.

Management support determines whether those objectives become funded projects. In Switzerland's early adoption phase, individuals' openness to crypto has influenced how opportunities and reputational risks are weighed. Support has sometimes come from senior leadership at the outset; elsewhere, internal teams have built it through years of practical work and risk assessment.



> Management support was something we built over several years through education, practical experience and open discussions about the risks. We involved the key stakeholders throughout the process and used hands-on demonstrations, not just presentations, to show how the technology and our risk controls worked.

Serge Kaulitz, Luzerner Kantonalbank

Resources shape what that support can deliver. Larger institutions can spread development costs across more customers, while banks with internal engineering expertise have greater scope to assemble their own systems. Smaller banks face a different calculation when the same specialists must support multiple priorities. Size alone, however, does not establish either readiness or ambition.

Shared Infrastructure Is Widening Participation

The growing provider market is making that resource constraint less decisive. Swiss banks can increasingly source custody, execution and integration through established partners, including specialists that grew out of the Swiss ecosystem itself, such as Sygnum and SEBA, now AMINA. This allows additional institutions to enter without reproducing the development work of the pioneers.

BancaStato offers a concrete example. Its 2026 launch connects Sygnum's services with its Avaloq environment, supporting crypto trading through existing web and mobile banking without a separate order-management system. St.Galler Kantonalbank's initial collaboration with AMINA similarly provided a straightforward route into custody and trading. These partnerships connect specialist capabilities directly with established retail distribution.

Existing relationships between banks provide another route. Infrastructure providers can extend crypto over connections already used for traditional assets, concentrating much of the technical work upstream.



> Partner banks can largely reuse their existing connections to us. Much of the infrastructure work has already been done on our side.

Peter Hubli, Zürcher Kantonalbank

The implication is significant for Switzerland's smaller retail banks: offering crypto is becoming less dependent on building a substantial internal technology operation. Governance, provider oversight and operational readiness still require work, but technical integration no longer necessarily dominates the project.

What We Expect Next

We expect this combination of wider demand, domestic competition and more accessible infrastructure to produce four developments:

01	**Basic access will spread further.**	Specialist platforms and growing adoption among peer institutions will make further Swiss launches easier to approve. Late entrants, however, will mainly defend existing customer relationships. Early movers have already captured much of the opportunity to differentiate and acquire clients through crypto access alone.
02	**Most offerings will remain deliberately basic.**	A closed trading-and-custody service can satisfy clients making a new allocation, but it cannot consolidate holdings already kept onchain. External transfers address that gap while introducing greater AML, monitoring and operational demands. Most banks will add them cautiously, while only very few will pursue lending, staking or DeFi connectivity.
03	**Some established providers will bring custody in-house.**	Banks treating crypto as an additional investment product can continue relying on specialist providers. Those preparing for tokenized assets, digital money or B2B services have stronger reasons to control custody and blockchain connectivity themselves. They may still purchase technology and execution, but will seek greater control over operations and future product changes.
04	**Digital money will remain concentrated among banks with a corporate use case.**	For the long tail of Swiss retail banks, stablecoins and tokenized deposits are unlikely to become near-term priorities. Activity will concentrate among institutions serving multinational companies, where 24/7 treasury, cross-border settlement and cash management can create tangible value. Progress will remain gradual and depend on how many multinational clients each bank serves and whether their counterparties join compatible networks.

The CHF stablecoin sandbox illustrates how that last agenda extends beyond the retail crypto market. Raiffeisen and BCV participate alongside PostFinance, ZKB and other institutions in testing potential applications. Their involvement reflects interest in future banking infrastructure, rather than a common strategy for crypto investing.

The next phase should therefore combine broader distribution of established crypto services with selective investment in new financial applications. The four case studies that follow illustrate different positions within this wider Swiss market.



Zürcher Kantonalbank

Zürcher Kantonalbank (ZKB) is Switzerland's largest cantonal bank and the country's third-largest credit institution, with CHF 206.2 billion in total assets. Founded in 1870 and owned by the Canton of Zurich, it provides retail, corporate and private banking, as well as asset management services.

11/2021
Joint lead manager for the first digital bond issued in a fully regulated environment

02/2023
Sole lead manager for the City of Lugano's CHF 100 million digital bond

11/2023
Joint lead manager for the first CHF bond settled in wCBDC under Helvetia III

09/2024
Launch of crypto offering for retail and B2B clients

04/2026
Founding member of CHF Stablecoin Sandbox

01 Protecting the Existing Banking Franchise

ZKB's entry into crypto began with demand from other banks. Already relying on ZKB for foreign exchange and securities trading, these institutions wanted an established banking partner to help them offer crypto to their own customers.

The concern was that leaving this demand unanswered would create an opening for rival banks. Once connected to a cantonal bank through crypto, a competitor could bundle these new services with more attractive pricing across its wider offering.

The offering has supported retention of those relationships. Crypto revenues have grown strongly from a standing start, but remain small relative to the bank. The strategic value lies partly in the business ZKB protects, rather than solely in the new revenues it generates.

02 Owning Custody, Partnering on Trading

To serve other banks, ZKB wanted to perform at least one core function itself. It chose custody, where it could draw on its AAA credit rating and reputation for security, while outsourcing trade execution to Crypto Finance and AMINA Bank.

Fireblocks provides the custody technology, but ZKB holds the private keys and acts as legal custodian. Each partner bank has its own wallet within ZKB's setup.

This division of responsibilities could evolve. ZKB would consider bringing trading in-house once volumes and revenues justify it, although capital requirements remain an obstacle. The approach reflects a deliberate sequence: take responsibility where the bank's strengths matter most, use partners elsewhere, and revisit the balance as the business develops.

03 Integrating with Existing Banking Systems

ZKB worked with Avaloq, its existing securities-system provider, to connect Fireblocks to its legacy infrastructure through an intermediary layer. Acting as a translator, this layer allows the existing system to process information from Fireblocks without extensive modifications.

The approach also reflected the resources a direct integration would have required. Working with Avaloq reduced the demands on ZKB's internal teams and core system, albeit at considerable cost.

Partner banks can largely reuse existing connections to ZKB with limited system adjustments. Onboarding is therefore driven less by technical integration than by regulatory and administrative processes, including engagement with FINMA.

04 What Comes Next

ZKB is introducing limited external crypto transfers and considering staking, but plans no new cryptocurrencies or crypto-backed lending. Continuous collateral monitoring, margin management and conservative LTV ratios weaken the lending case, while public ownership and governance reinforce caution around reputational risks.

Beyond crypto, ZKB sees long-term potential in stablecoins, tokenized assets and new payment rails. Its participation in Project Helvetia and the CHF stablecoin sandbox reflects this direction across payments and securities settlement.

To identify tangible benefits, ZKB is increasingly examining its own operations, particularly collateral and cash management. One possibility is using tokenized money market funds to replace cash prefunding at correspondent banks, establishing an internal use case that could later inform client services.



> The **crypto business is the low-hanging fruit**. The fundamental change for banks lies in **tokenized assets, stablecoins and new payment rails.**

Peter Hubli

Head of Digital Assets • Zürcher Kantonalbank

THE BLOCKSTORIES VIEW

ZKB's digital-asset strategy serves two distinct objectives. Its crypto offering protects existing B2B trading relationships by enabling partner banks to add crypto through connections already used for traditional assets. This makes digital assets an extension of ZKB's infrastructure role, rather than only a retail proposition.

With broader capital-market adoption still moving slowly, ZKB is turning the tokenization question inward. The immediate test is whether tokenized assets can improve its own collateral and cash management, for example by using tokenized money-market funds in place of prefunded cash. This allows the bank to assess tokenization against measurable internal efficiency gains while the external market continues to develop. If the model proves valuable, ZKB can then examine whether the same infrastructure could also serve its banking partners.



Luzerner Kantonalbank

Luzerner Kantonalbank (LUKB) is Central Switzerland's largest bank, holding an AA+ rating and CHF 60 billion in total assets. Founded in 1850 and majority-owned by the Canton of Lucerne, it is incorporated as a private-law limited company and listed on the SIX Swiss Exchange. It provides retail, corporate and private banking, as well as asset management services.

02/2024
Launch of crypto offering for retail

10/2024
First Swiss universal bank to enable crypto deposits and withdrawals to and from external wallets

09/2025
First Swiss universal bank to launch Lombard lending

12/2025
Enabled institutional & B2B clients to access the crypto-platform via a dedicated interface

06/2026
Introduced five order types in e-banking, including Request for Quote (RFQ), Limit, Stop-Market, and Stop-Limit

01 Integrating Crypto into E-Banking

LUKB's crypto offering grew out of research into how customers wanted to access digital assets. The initial demand came mainly from retail clients seeking simpler access, without unfamiliar exchanges or responsibility for managing private keys.

The bank had also measured outflows to crypto exchanges. Bringing these investments into its own offering could retain assets, strengthen relationships with younger customers and attract new clients. A sustainable business case was therefore essential.

These objectives shaped the experience: crypto became part of existing e-banking, allowing customers to buy and hold digital assets alongside traditional investments. Convenience and trusted custody formed the proposition, with demand subsequently broadening towards private banking and institutional clients.

02 Building for Control and Flexibility

The bank assembled its own custody and trading setup using external technology providers. Retaining expertise and control over product development justified the greater initial investment.

After reviewing more than 50 vendors, the bank centred its architecture on custody, trading connectivity and order management, and AML tools. It also developed its own application within Avaloq and its own customer interface.

An internal development team and existing expertise in trading systems helped make this possible. The resulting setup gives LUKB room to adjust order handling, processes and customer features as requirements evolve, while retaining control over how those changes reach its banking systems.

03 Building Confidence Before Expanding

The progress was built on years of preparation. Research began in 2016, followed by proofs of concept, cross-departmental collaboration and demonstrations for management. An initially sceptical board gained confidence through detailed risk assessments, internal reviews and hands-on experience.

Before launch, the bank trained more than 440 relationship managers, alongside key stakeholders. Education covered both the offering and the controls behind it, including regulatory requirements and risk management.

The rollout followed the same incremental logic. Trading and custody came first, followed by automated transfers, savings plans and Bitcoin and Ether as collateral. Each step required further work on liquidity, compliance and round-the-clock risk management, allowing the bank to address increasingly complex activities.

04 What Comes Next

LUKB aims to scale its crypto business through B2B and institutional services. Its strategy extends to 2030, with a modular setup supporting new crypto and blockchain-based products as demand and regulatory requirements develop.

The offering already includes two stablecoins, while tokenization and potential Swiss stablecoin issuance remain under consideration as regulation develops.

Several paths remain open: expanding the asset universe, adding services or developing tokenization applications. LUKB has prioritised the ability to adapt and bring relevant products to market as opportunities become clearer, without committing to a single forecast of where the market will go.



> We had people within the bank working on Bitcoin and blockchain **as early as 2014**. Having a **broad range of technical expertise in-house** enabled us to translate our requirements into Avaloq's front- and backends.

Serge Kaulitz

Head of Digital Assets • Luzerner Kantonalbank

THE BLOCKSTORIES VIEW

LUKB's case makes the strongest argument for treating flexibility itself as a return on infrastructure investment. The bank could not know in 2020 that transfers, savings plans and crypto-backed lending would become the features worth adding, just as it cannot know which tokenization use cases will matter five years from now.

For banks deciding how much of the stack to control, the calculation must include the cost of change alongside the initial launch cost. LUKB did not build every component itself; it retained control over how specialist systems connect with its core banking platform and customer interface. This required more integration work upfront, but reduced dependence on a single provider's roadmap. A narrow offering may still favour outsourcing, while banks expecting continued product development can justify control over the integration layer as reusable infrastructure.



PostFinance

PostFinance is one of Switzerland's largest retail financial institutions and a systemically important bank, serving around 2.4 million clients. Wholly owned by Swiss Post, it holds a leading position in Swiss payment transactions. A statutory ban on lending and mortgage origination makes payments and investment services central to its business model.

02/2024
First systemically important Swiss bank to launch direct crypto trading and custody, with Sygnum

01/2025
First systemically important Swiss bank to offer Ethereum staking

09/2025
First legally recognised cross-bank payment in tokenized deposits, with UBS and Sygnum

04/2026
Founding member of the CHF Stablecoin Sandbox

05/2026
Extended the crypto offering to corporate and institutional clients

01 Diversifying Beyond Payments

PostFinance's restriction on lending makes revenue diversification particularly important. Crypto offered a way to meet customer demand and develop a new income stream while building expertise in technology that could eventually reshape its core payments business.

The early-2024 launch benefited from strong market momentum. Trading activity exceeded initial expectations, and commercial performance helped sustain management support for further development.

An estimated 95% of crypto users were existing PostFinance clients, consistent with the priority of keeping their investment activity within the bank. Crypto also became an entry point into its broader investment offering: some customers began with crypto before adopting traditional trading or investment mandates, extending the commercial benefit beyond the product itself.

02 Linking Crypto with Traditional Investing

That connection also runs in the other direction: PostFinance is bringing crypto into managed portfolios. A retail mandate with a CHF 5,000 minimum includes a 5% crypto allocation and is available to customers in its highest risk category.

Alongside this integration, the bank is working to expand and improve staking beyond its initial Ether offering. External transfers are another priority: their absence prevents customers from moving existing crypto holdings into PostFinance without first selling them.

Together, these developments address both sides of the investment relationship: adding crypto exposure to traditional portfolios and giving existing crypto investors more reasons to hold their assets with PostFinance.

03 Reassessing What to Own

As the offering expands, PostFinance is reassessing the underlying infrastructure. Sygnum currently provides custody and brokerage; the bank is exploring whether to bring selected capabilities in-house, particularly custody.

Greater control could support new services and reduce dependence on a single partner. The operating model remains under assessment, with internal capabilities potentially complementing external partnerships.

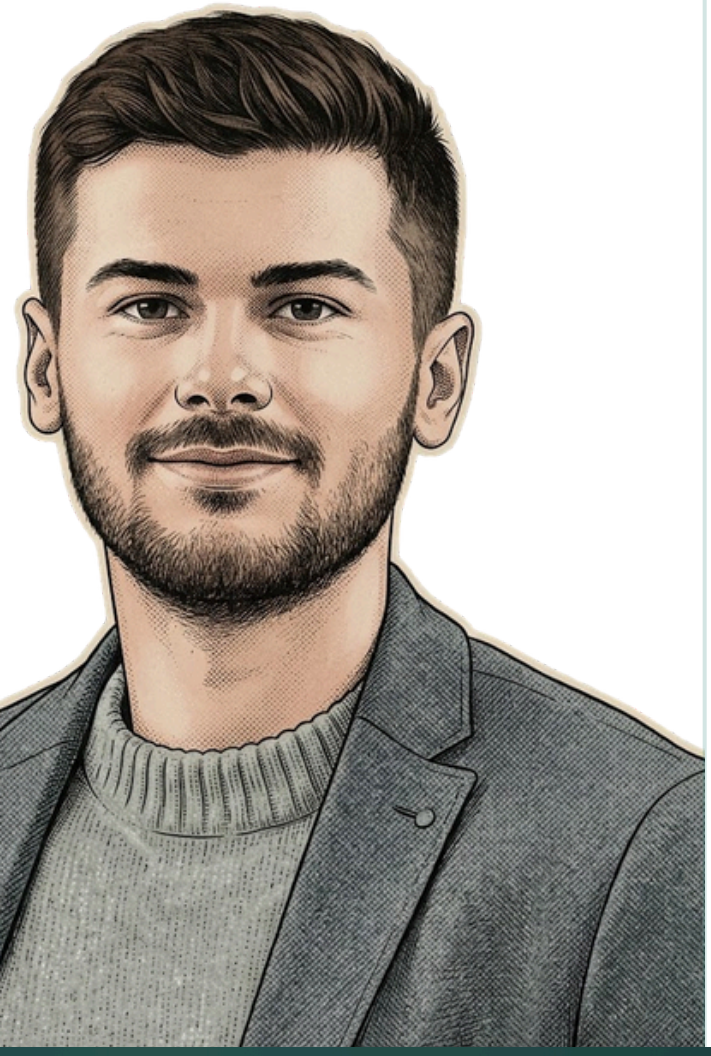
The rationale also extends beyond investing. PostFinance wants the flexibility to develop payment and digital-money applications, where infrastructure decisions become directly relevant to its core business.

04 What Comes Next

In payments, PostFinance has an established business to protect and improve. Deposit-token experiments with UBS and Sygnum, participation in Project Agorá and the Swiss franc stablecoin sandbox reflect its ambition to help shape the next generation of payment infrastructure.

International payments offer particular scope for improvement. Yet efficiency gains for users do not automatically make issuance viable: low Swiss franc interest rates limit the reserve income available to fund a stablecoin operation.

The sandbox brings these two sides together, testing customer applications alongside issuer economics. Adoption depends on making both work under regulation that supports deployment at scale.



> The decision to launch a crypto offering was driven by the recognition that the underlying infrastructure could provide a **foundation for the broader DLT-driven transformation** of banking services.

Kay Wäfler

Digital Assets Manager • PostFinance

THE BLOCKSTORIES VIEW

For PostFinance, staying at the forefront of payments is a strategic necessity. Payments are central to its business, and its lending restriction makes protecting and expanding that business particularly important. Digital money could change both what customers can do with payments and how banks settle them.

Participation in the Swiss stablecoin sandbox and Agorá gives PostFinance a role in shaping those changes, from domestic applications to cross-border settlement. The strategic aim is to remain the payment provider its customers use as the infrastructure behind those services evolves.



Swissquote

Swissquote is one of Switzerland's leading online banks, with CHF 96.3 billion in client assets as of June 30, 2026. Founded in 1996 and listed on the SIX Swiss Exchange, it provides online trading, investment, and banking services to private and institutional clients.

07/2017
First Swiss bank to launch direct Bitcoin trading

10/2018
First bank worldwide to enable clients to participate directly in ICOs

03/2019
Launched crypto custody and transfers to and from external wallets

10/2022
Launched SQX, its proprietary cryptocurrency exchange

10/2024
Launch of crypto saving plans

01 Extending the Platform Into Crypto

Swissquote's entry into crypto in 2017 began with support from senior leadership, including its founders and technology management. For an online investment platform, crypto offered another asset class customers could access through an existing banking relationship.

The initial model prioritised brokerage. Swissquote used Bitstamp for execution, with assets held through BitGo, while managing the customer interface and working through the setup with legal advisers and FINMA.

This allowed the bank to launch before building its own custody infrastructure. As holdings grew, however, relying on external custody became a more significant consideration, prompting investment in greater operational control.

02 Taking Control of Custody and Execution

Swissquote subsequently developed custody capabilities using technology from Crypto Finance and Taurus. An integration layer connected the systems and enabled more automated deposits and withdrawals, making the offering easier to use for both retail and professional clients.

The bank also built its own crypto exchange SQX. Its central limit order book matches Swissquote customer orders with one another and with external market makers, giving it an alternative to routing trades through third-party exchanges.

Its existing customer base made this relevant: internal order flow could contribute liquidity, while control over execution helped address the needs of larger, price-sensitive investors.

03 Making Crypto Holdings More Useful

After the technical foundation had been set, Swissquote expanded beyond trading by connecting crypto holdings to customers' wider financial needs. Staking lets them earn rewards, Lombard lending provides liquidity without an immediate sale, and card payments let them spend through crypto conversion.

Lending makes the connection to traditional banking particularly concrete: borrowing capacity can reflect both eligible crypto and traditional assets within the same portfolio, with additional assessment for larger facilities. Capital requirements and the treatment of crypto collateral during liquidation nevertheless limit lending capacity.

Together, these services give customers more reasons to keep assets at Swissquote: they can earn, borrow and spend against wealth that would otherwise serve primarily as an investment.

04 Banking Crypto Wealth

Beyond existing customers buying crypto, Swissquote attracted investors whose wealth originated in digital assets, including long-term Bitcoin holders. Their needs extend beyond trading: they want access to banking services and liquidity while retaining crypto exposure.

This helps explain the broader offering described above. Custody and Lombard lending give these customers ways to hold and use their wealth, while access to traditional investments allows them to diversify within the same account.

The fit is also behavioural. Swissquote's self-directed model lets crypto-native investors make their own decisions, with the bank providing the tools rather than directing how they invest.



> Having a fairly complete offering so early compared to the market allowed us **to capture a new clientele of crypto-native holders,** particularly focused on Bitcoin.

Carlos Martin Doncel
Digital Assets Lead • Swissquote

THE BLOCKSTORIES VIEW

Swissquote's combination of self-directed investing and banking services fits a particular customer: someone whose wealth grew in crypto and who wants financial flexibility without surrendering investment control. Customers can retain crypto exposure, borrow against eligible holdings and diversify into traditional assets within the same relationship.

These capabilities give customers practical reasons to move assets from a crypto exchange to Swissquote, turning its banking license into a commercial advantage. For banks pursuing this segment, trusted custody opens the door, while useful services determine how much wealth follows.

III.

MARKET SEGMENT 03

Private Banks

CASE STUDIES

GROUPE Banque Richelieu

MAERKI BAUMANN & CO. AG
PRIVATBANK

Swiss Private Banking: Access Came Early, Commitment Stayed Selective

The wealth that Swiss private banks look after rarely stays in one country. A client might live in Dubai, run companies in three jurisdictions and keep a Geneva account because that is where the investing, the borrowing and the family's affairs come together. For banks built around such relationships, digital assets offer two distinct openings: helping existing clients invest in crypto, and winning clients whose fortunes were made there.

A decade after Swiss investors first gained access to regulated crypto-linked securities products, both openings have established providers. What the decade has failed to produce is a shared level of commitment. Some banks run full-service crypto desks; others allow a trade and leave it at that; several have stayed away altogether. Launch dates explain little of this. The relationships each bank wants to build help explain why their approaches differ.

One Market, Different Commercial Priorities

KPMG counted 79 Swiss private banks in May 2026. The 68 it analysed in detail managed CHF 3.5 trillion at the end of 2025. Behind that headline sits a crowded and varied field: international wealth managers such as Julius Baer, UBP and EFG share the market with partner-owned houses and small specialists, each with its own clientele, resources and investment convictions.

Those differences decide what a crypto offering has to do. A client who wants an occasional allocation is served by access through the account they already hold. A client arriving with a substantial Bitcoin position needs more: a bank that can trace where the money came from, accept the transfer and support whatever comes next, from a Lombard loan to a diversification plan. Blockchain companies and foundations bring a third set of demands, including accounts, conversions and everyday operational banking.

One bank can serve all three. The economics of doing so, however, diverge sharply. Serving occasional demand may require only a modest offering, provided the business covers its ongoing costs. Going after clients the bank has never served before only makes sense if onboarding leads to assets that stay and relationships that grow.



> For us, it was the opportunity to gain new assets instead of losing something. We were particularly successful with clients who had made their fortunes in crypto and wanted to diversify away from a single asset class. That requires understanding how those assets were generated and providing knowledgeable advice on what comes next.
>
> **Milko Hensel,** Maerki Baumann

Maerki Baumann's experience shows both sides of that calculation. Crypto platforms competed hard on trading and custody, squeezing what those services could earn. The value showed up elsewhere, in conversions and in the wider banking relationships that followed. The commercial test therefore extends beyond the initial transfer: does the relationship generate enough lasting business to justify acquiring and serving it?

Early Entry Created Choice Rather Than Consensus

Swiss private banks first approached crypto through capabilities they already had. Vontobel drew on its structured-products expertise to issue a Bitcoin tracker certificate in 2016. Arab Bank Switzerland established a digital-asset business in 2019, while Julius Baer introduced direct services for clients booked in Switzerland in 2020. Bordier followed through Sygnum in 2021, showing how partnerships could bring crypto into an established private-banking relationship.

These early moves created several ways to participate, but no common direction for the segment. Many Swiss private banks still have no publicly documented direct crypto offering. Among those that do participate, the scope ranges from investment products and basic trading to services for clients whose businesses or wealth are rooted in crypto.

MARKET OVERVIEW

Three models of crypto banking

INDIRECT EXPOSURE — FULL SERVICE DEPTH

01 Crypto-linked investment products

Exposure solely through certificates, funds and other securities, whether issued by the bank or accessed through its investment offering.

Vontobel

02 Crypto trading and custody

Buying, holding and selling crypto within a banking relationship. Supported assets and transfer capabilities vary.

bordier 1844 · Sygnum · Bergos · PKB · BBVA

03 Integrated Crypto Banking

Additional capabilities such as lending, staking, investment management or banking for crypto businesses. Offering varies.

Julius Bär · Maerki Baumann & Co. AG Privatbank · Arab Bank Switzerland · Banque Richelieu

The differences become clearer when looking at what clients can actually do. Bordier does execution-only and explicitly excludes lending and staking. Julius Baer accommodates transfers and considers crypto collateral case by case. Arab Bank Switzerland extends its offering into staking, financing and legacy planning. A trading-and-custody launch can therefore support quite different banking propositions.

The Vendor Decision Outlasts the Launch

Look beneath the offerings and the same handful of specialist providers keeps appearing. Their availability has reduced how much banks need to build themselves, above all for those without large development teams. But the arrangements they support carry different amounts of operational responsibility, and the differences matter.

IMPLEMENTATION

Three different vendor plays

Use a specialist sub-custodian	JULIUS BAER · AMINA BORDIER · SYGNUM	Delegate custody while retaining the client relationship and oversight responsibilities.
Use an external custody technology	ARAB BANK SWITZERLAND · TAURUS SYZ · TAURUS	Purchase software to support custody capabilities within the bank.
Extend an existing outsourcing relationship	MAERKI BAUMANN · INCORE BANQUE RICHELIEU · INCORE	Fit digital assets into an established operating model.

For a bank weighing entry, this reframes the problem. The foundations are available off the shelf. Buying them provides a technical starting point. The bank still has to decide how the service will operate and why clients should choose it.

That answer lives inside the institution: which sources of wealth its compliance teams can assess, which relationships its management will accept and how confidently its relationship managers can handle a client whose money arrived as tokens. Management commitment is what converts those choices into funded capabilities, and what keeps them funded when demand goes quiet.

The vendor decision, meanwhile, outlasts the launch. Maerki Baumann found that infrastructure well suited to its first offering grew less accommodating as transfer and connectivity requirements evolved. What a bank buys on day one shapes its running costs, its service menu and its room to adapt for years afterwards.

Tokenization Has a Separate Commercial Logic

Running alongside the client-facing crypto business is a quieter line of work on how ordinary investments get delivered. For institutions with asset-management and securities-servicing arms, that gives tokenization a rationale entirely detached from whether anyone wants Bitcoin.

Pictet's 2025 pilot with SIX shows what this looks like in practice. Corporate bonds were tokenized and allocated in fractional quantities to portfolios run by Pictet Asset Management, a test of whether portfolio customisation could become more flexible and more scalable. The prize, if there is one, sits in investment construction and processing.

Turning a pilot into a recurring service demands one more thing: proof that the improvement is worth the disruption of changing what already works.



> No client has ever asked me where their Apple stock is stored. What matters is whether it is a good asset to invest in. Tokenization will become relevant when it lowers costs and removes friction. But as long as no one can put numbers behind the business case, why should I move if it is cheaper and easier in the existing world?
>
> **Markus Abbassi,** Banque Richelieu Switzerland

For private banks, the applications that survive that question will have an obvious beneficiary, whether through better portfolio delivery, simpler servicing or lower operating costs. A tokenized wrapper on its own creates neither client demand nor a reason to invest.

What We Expect Next

As basic crypto access becomes easier to offer and harder to differentiate, we expect private banks to focus on four areas where their client relationships and investment capabilities can still create value:

01 **Basic access will become harder to differentiate.**

As large wealth managers worldwide introduce trading and custody, further Swiss launches will become easier to approve. However, clients with substantial crypto wealth now have several regulated banking options, leaving new entrants with far less scope to acquire them through basic access alone. For most late movers, the case will centre on retention and service completeness, rather than differentiation or new-client acquisition.

02 **Crypto-backed lending will expand through relationship-led underwriting.**

More private banks are likely to add it because close knowledge of a client's wider balance sheet and liquidity needs makes individually structured facilities a natural extension of the relationship. Existing providers will meanwhile work towards higher loan-to-value ratios and larger facilities as they gain operational experience, although volatility and capital requirements will keep that expansion gradual.

03 **Onchain vaults are a logical next step for banks with the deepest crypto capabilities.**

Institutions already supporting external transfers, staking or lending have the closest operational starting point for offering suitable clients access to curated crypto-native yield strategies. Doing so will require clear accountability for investment decisions and credible controls around smart-contract, liquidity and counterparty risk.

04 **Tokenization will progress where it changes the economics of investment delivery.**

For large private banks managing billions of francs across thousands of client portfolios, tokenization and smart contracts may create the most value by making portfolio management more scalable. They could automate allocations and rebalancing, reduce idle cash between transactions, and streamline capital calls, interest payments and reconciliation. The constraint is the investable universe: this model only works once enough approved funds, equities, credit and cash instruments are available onchain and integrated with existing banking systems.

The case studies that follow examine how Maerki Baumann and Banque Richelieu Switzerland have made these choices for their own clients and operating models.



MAERKI BAUMANN & CO. AG

PRIVATBANK

Maerki Baumann is an independent, family-owned Swiss private bank founded in 1932 and headquartered in Zurich, with approximately CHF 13 billion in client assets under management. It provides wealth management, investment advisory and corporate banking services to private clients, entrepreneurs and companies.

02/2019
Began onboarding clients with wealth originating from cryptocurrencies, subject to source-of-funds verification

04/2019
Launched business accounts for blockchain companies and services supporting ICOs and STOs

06/2020
Launched crypto trading and custody for private and institutional clients

03/2021
Integrated digital assets into its investment advisory and asset management services

03/2024
Consolidated its digital asset services under the ARCHIP brand

01 Banking an Underserved Client Base

Maerki Baumann entered digital assets to serve a client segment that had previously been shunned by most banks. Its existing private-banking customers showed little crypto activity, while blockchain companies and foundations struggled to obtain banking services.

Support from the executive team and board enabled the bank to pursue both opportunities: crypto trading and custody for private clients, alongside banking services for businesses in the emerging sector.

The bank developed capabilities to assess crypto-related sources of funds and transaction histories within its existing AML and KYC approach. This gave it a basis for accepting relationships that other institutions were reluctant to serve, connecting Switzerland's growing blockchain ecosystem with conventional banking.

02 Finding Value Beyond Crypto Trading

The commercial results were different from what Maerki Baumann initially expected. Non-bank crypto platforms competed aggressively on price, which reduced the profitability of crypto trading and custody.

The more valuable opportunity emerged around the broader banking relationship. Clients can transfer stablecoins, Bitcoin or other digital assets to the bank, convert them into fiat and use the proceeds for operational or personal needs, while relying on a regulated institution.

This can also lead to wealth-management relationships. Clients who built significant wealth in crypto may later diversify into equities, bonds, real estate or other traditional assets. By understanding the source of that wealth and helping allocate it, Maerki Baumann can add advice and investment management to the relationship.

03 Adapting an Outsourced Operating Model

These services initially relied on external infrastructure, including InCore Bank for banking and transaction support, consistent with Maerki Baumann's broader outsourcing model.

As client requirements became more specific, limitations emerged around transfer efficiency, supported protocols and connections to additional providers. Infrastructure suited to the initial launch offered less flexibility for subsequent services, while changing providers requires time and coordination.

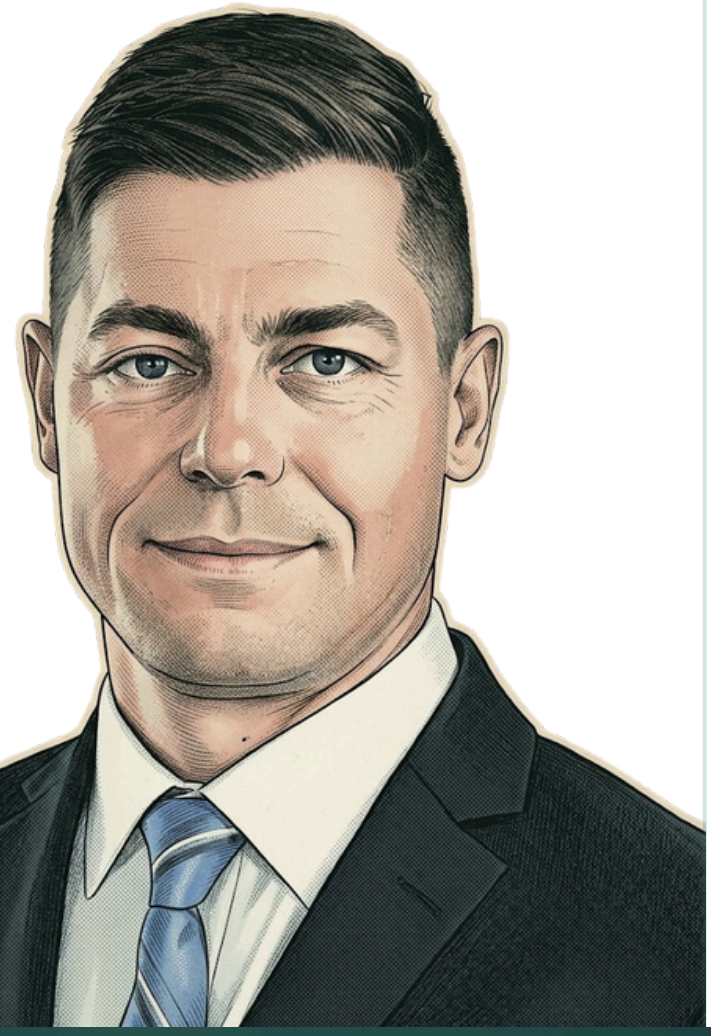
Looking back, the bank would now prioritize fast, low-cost transfers and interoperability. Its experience also shows that technology is only part of the challenge: expansion requires internal risk alignment, while crypto-backed lending remains constrained by capital requirements and conservative collateral policies.

04 What's Next

Those constraints shape the next priorities. Maerki Baumann wants to expand its crypto-backed Lombard lending beyond the current 20% loan-to-value ratio and offer larger facilities. DeFi is not currently part of its offering, given limited client demand.

The bank also sees an opportunity to extend its corporate services gradually to related tech companies, where complex ownership and investor structures can similarly complicate access to banking.

Tokenization is approached more selectively. The bank is preparing to process and trade security tokens, although demand remains limited at present. The goal is to support relevant assets as needs emerge, rather than taking a leading role in token issuance.



> As a private bank, you have to provide clients with **access to the broadest possible range of investable assets.** They must be able to invest in and divest from any asset class, and digital assets should be no exception.

Milko Hensel

Team Head Tech Banking • Maerki Baumann

THE BLOCKSTORIES VIEW

Maerki Baumann shows how specialist capabilities can give a private bank access to an emerging corporate client segment that other banks struggle to serve. Accepting crypto proceeds and handling complex sources of wealth solves an immediate need. Providing the account that funds business operations creates a more lasting relationship.

The larger opportunity is to become the banking partner these companies keep as their needs expand, with potential relationships extending to founders' personal wealth. For private banks equipped to assess these clients, the value of crypto expertise therefore reaches beyond transaction fees into the broader business it can attract.



GROUPE
Banque Richelieu

Groupe Banque Richelieu is an international private banking group managing more than EUR 11 billion in assets. It serves private clients, family offices and external asset managers with tailored investment solutions. In 2025, the group acquired Kaleido Privatbank—renamed Banque Richelieu Switzerland—to expand its digital asset capabilities.

07/2022
Launched its digital asset offering through InCore Bank's infrastructure

11/2022
Launched the Kaleido Digital Asset Core Strategy, providing an equal weight approach to profit from long-term growth of the technology.

02/2023
Expanded the offering to include staking

07/2025
Acquired by Groupe Banque Richelieu and subsequently renamed Banque Richelieu Switzerland

01 Motive: Differentiation

Banque Richelieu Switzerland's digital-assets strategy began under its former identity, Kaleido, as the bank repositioned from transaction banking towards wealth management and prepared for a sale.

Crypto expertise offered a way to differentiate a small institution specialising in tailored financial solutions. The board approved the project in late 2021, before a dedicated specialist joined to implement it. That commitment helped establish the initiative beyond a single market cycle.

The objective combined attracting new clients with preserving revenue during the transformation. Digital-assets capabilities subsequently became a distinctive competence within the Richelieu group, which acquired the bank.

02 Winning Wealthy Crypto Investors

This positioning shaped the initial offering. Transfers into and out of custody were available from launch because prospective clients already held substantial Bitcoin and Ether positions. Selling those assets elsewhere and repurchasing them through the bank offered little appeal.

The proposition centred on secure custody, Swiss regulatory oversight and consolidated reporting for clients, external asset managers and family offices. These were predominantly long-term holders seeking a banking relationship, rather than active traders.

The offering has since expanded beyond execution into mandates and transaction-based advice. Selected mandates diversify across investment strategies, including exposure through regulated DeFi funds. This provides access within conventional investment structures, without the bank directly deploying client assets into DeFi protocols.

03 External Infrastructure, Internal Experts

With roughly 30 employees, the bank already relied on Incore Bank for major back-office functions. Extending that setup to crypto avoided adding another provider and further operational complexity.

What remained internal was the ability to understand clients' crypto activity and bring it into a banking relationship. Relationship managers could involve specialists to assess holdings, transfers and sources of wealth.

That expertise also matters when clients arrive with fiat proceeds from exchanges. Properly documenting the history for compliance and auditors can enable substantial inflows, extending the commercial value well beyond crypto trading revenue.

04 Focus on Banking Integration

Following the acquisition, the immediate priority is aligning the digital-assets setup with the wider Richelieu group. This includes reviewing audit requirements, regulatory arrangements and the conditions for serving clients across jurisdictions.

The existing range already addresses many client needs, while subdued demand reduces the urgency of further launches. Resources are therefore focused on integration and maintaining the offering.

Tokenization faces a separate economic test. For the bank's clients, the attraction lies in the investment and its contribution to wealth preservation. Moving to tokenized infrastructure would need to deliver measurable advantages in cost or execution. Access to tokenized assets alone provides limited justification for another infrastructure investment.



> Ultimately, the expertise we built created more value than any single crypto product. It helped us continuously **onboard crypto-native clients and expand those relation-ships** into traditional wealth management.

Markus Abbassi
Head of Digital Assets • Banque Richelieu

THE BLOCKSTORIES VIEW

Richelieu's experience shows why crypto expertise can earn its return through conventional wealth management. Even when a client transfers fiat from an exchange, the bank must understand how that wealth was generated and document it convincingly. The ability to do so can determine whether a substantial relationship is accepted.

For a boutique with roughly 30 employees, combining external infrastructure with internal expertise makes this opportunity accessible. Its value should therefore be assessed across the assets and relationships it enables the bank to acquire. Measuring only crypto trading and custody revenues would miss part of the business case.

SYGNUM AMINA

How Specialist Banks Are Evolving

IV.
DIGITAL-ASSET BANKS

Banking Switzerland's Emerging Crypto Economy

Switzerland's blockchain ecosystem developed faster than the banking services available to support it. Companies could raise and hold capital in crypto, yet struggle to obtain an account to pay salaries and suppliers. Meanwhile, professional investors wanted access to digital assets through institutions that could combine secure custody with the services and oversight they expected from a bank.

Sygnum and AMINA, originally called SEBA, were established around these needs. Both received Swiss banking licences in August 2019, creating institutions whose core business was connecting digital assets with conventional finance. Their clients included blockchain companies, foundations, entrepreneurs and institutional investors requiring more than an exchange account.

Custody and trading provided a starting point. Fiat accounts, payments, secured lending and investment services made the relationship more useful. As established banks began exploring their own offerings, the capabilities developed for these clients also became a service those banks could buy.

Direct Banking Creates the Foundation for Bank Partnerships

For Sygnum, serving other banks was part of the strategy from the outset. Direct clients came first because their needs already existed; prospective bank partners still had to agree on a strategy and prepare for launch.

Those initial relationships supplied operational experience and credibility. Partnerships then opened a larger distribution channel, allowing customers to access the specialist's services through their existing bank.



> We started with the direct client business, which earned us credibility as a digital-asset specialist. That was the prerequisite for banks to even consider us in a B2B context. Direct clients still account for more than three-quarters of our revenues, but B2B is where we are growing fastest.
>
> **Thomas Eichenberger,** Sygnum

The benefit extends beyond distribution. Partner banks bring volumes that support continued investment in the platform, while greater scale strengthens Sygnum's proposition to larger institutional clients. Direct banking and B2B can therefore reinforce each other.

A second growth avenue is to deepen the role these banks play in clients' everyday financial activity. At AMINA, crypto trading and lending dominated the early business, but demand is increasingly shifting toward recurring banking and payments. Regulated crypto firms, for example, are seeking fiat accounts, virtual IBANs and connections to stablecoin payment rails. That broadens the opportunity beyond banks launching crypto investment products. Exchanges, brokers and other financial platforms also need regulated banking infrastructure behind their own services.

Why the Banking Licence Matters Commercially

This broader demand highlights an important advantage of the specialists' model: their banking licence allows them to combine digital-asset infrastructure with services that non-bank providers cannot offer in the same relationship. A bank launching digital assets can buy custody software or execution services from several sources. Sygnum and AMINA can combine those capabilities with fiat deposits, payments and balance-sheet lending.

For a crypto platform, that can mean obtaining both asset services and the banking infrastructure needed to receive and move customer money. For another bank, it means working with a counterparty already subject to familiar prudential supervision, governance and operational requirements.



> It is reassuring for banks to work with a provider subject to the same regulatory requirements, oversight, governance and risk-management principles as they are. This was particularly true when we launched in 2019, and it is even more relevant today.
>
> **Thomas Eichenberger,** Sygnum

Technology is still a core part of the offering, but neither bank needs to own every component itself. Both combine proprietary capabilities with external technology. AMINA, for example, uses Fireblocks and Taurus alongside its own deep-cold-storage infrastructure. The advantage is therefore less about the technology itself and more about how it is packaged. A client can access custody, trading and banking services through one regulated provider rather than coordinating several separate relationships. That does not remove the need for outsourcing oversight, but it can reduce the number of counterparties and operational handoffs involved.

Partnerships Become More Modular as the Market Expands

As banks gain experience, some will want to bring more of the stack in-house. Sygnum says prospective partners increasingly ask about this before choosing their first provider, with custody often the starting point because it sits closest to the bank's core proposition. That shifts more operational responsibility to the bank and creates demand for a more modular model: larger institutions may run custody themselves while sourcing execution, liquidity or support for selected assets, whereas smaller banks are more likely to keep using an integrated service.

That same modularity creates opportunities beyond banks adding crypto products. With Nu Global, Sygnum provides fiat-to-crypto conversion, trading, stablecoin access and custody, while Nu controls the customer relationship and product interface. Sygnum is therefore not only supplying capabilities to banks building digital-asset businesses, but also to financial platforms using those capabilities to enter new markets.

European expansion broadens the opportunity for both Sygnum and AMINA. Their Liechtenstein and Austrian authorisations respectively allow them to approach EU institutions through locally regulated entities. The addressable market now spans banks looking for a full platform, larger institutions buying selected services and financial platforms embedding digital-asset infrastructure. As more partners build capabilities of their own, their position will increasingly depend on remaining useful after that happens.

Beyond Trading and Custody: Tokenized Products, Credit and Payments

Sygnum's tokenization activities show how that broader proposition is taking shape. Its work with Hamilton Lane and Apex brought DLT share classes of a private-markets fund onto its platform. More recently, its Desygnate infrastructure supported Fidelity International's tokenized liquidity product, including an onchain fund registry, stablecoin subscriptions and automated settlement. These projects extend Sygnum's role into the issuance, administration and distribution of investment products.

The FalconX partnership adds another capability: access to a permissioned, overcollateralized onchain credit facility. Sygnum acts as lender of record on behalf of eligible clients, integrating participation into its banking platform. The bank thereby helps clients access a selected onchain investment through an established onboarding and servicing relationship. This is a more specific proposition than simply providing a connection to DeFi protocols.

Alongside these investment products, Sygnum is developing experience in digital money. It participated in the Swiss deposit-token proof of concept and the joint CHF stablecoin sandbox. These remain distinct from commercial product launches, but position the bank to help shape how money moves between institutions and interacts with tokenized assets.

Payment connectivity is particularly visible in AMINA's recent development. Its payment network supports instant fiat transfers between members. Its announced Mesh integration targets simpler wallet verification and digital-asset deposits, with withdrawals and payouts identified as subsequent extensions. AMINA has also tested shared-ledger interbank payments with Incore Bank and Crypto Finance. Together, these initiatives address the movement of money between bank accounts, wallets and financial platforms.



> Accepting digital cash, such as stablecoins, requires capabilities beyond the basic technology stack needed for trading, including integration with fiat payment rails. Without careful planning, an organisation can ultimately find itself operating two parallel worlds.
>
> **Myles Harrison,** AMINA

What We Expect Next

01 **B2B growth will shift its centre of gravity from Switzerland to Europe.**

Both banks will continue to target Swiss institutions that have yet to launch crypto offerings, but their bigger growth focus is shifting toward the wider EU market. MiCA gives AMINA's Austrian and Sygnum's Liechtenstein entities passporting access, and smaller and mid-sized banks across Europe are more likely to rely on integrated partners than build custody and trading in-house.

02 **Payments and treasury services will become a more deliberate source of recurring business.**

AMINA is targeting the fiat accounts, virtual IBANs and payment flows used by crypto platforms, while Sygnum is developing settlement capabilities around tokenized products and digital money. The opportunity is to hold operating balances and process day-to-day transactions, but its value depends on becoming embedded in clients' core treasury processes rather than remaining an ancillary connection.

03 **Sygnum will deepen its role in bringing onchain investments into banking.**

We expect further development around tokenized funds, liquidity products and selected credit or yield strategies, supported by subscription, redemption and settlement capabilities. Adoption by its own clients can establish operating experience before distribution through partners. This will reinforce Sygnum's position as a specialist provider as the market matures.

Can Switzerland Keep Its Lead?

04

Switzerland's early adoption of crypto trading and custody gave banks practical digital-asset experience. Its lead in digital money and tokenization is less clear, as both depend on broader market participation: payments need counterparties, securities need investors and liquidity, and shared infrastructure needs sufficient scale.

Swiss institutions face these challenges alongside international peers, with regulation and CHF interest rates adding specific domestic considerations.



01

The Next Applications Require Banks to Work Together

As banks can introduce crypto access by connecting their customers to existing markets, creating a new settlement network requires institutions to agree on how money moves between them, which rules apply and how the service connects to their existing operations. The benefit to each participant depends partly on who else joins.

Swiss banks are participating in several joint initiatives to develop these networks together. They range from securities settlement in central bank money to programmable payments using bank deposits and stablecoins:

JOINT INITIATIVES

Building settlement networks together

INITIATIVE	PURPOSE AND PARTICIPANTS	CURRENT STAGE
Project Helvetia	Settle tokenized securities using wholesale central bank digital currency SNB BNS · Aargauische Kantonalbank · BCV · BLKB · Zürcher Kantonalbank · Basler Kantonalbank · Hypothekarbank Lenzburg · RAIFFEISEN · UBS	●●○ PRODUCTION PILOT
Deposit Token Proof of Concept	Use tokenized payment instructions to trigger off-chain fiat transfers, including an escrow-like asset exchange. UBS · PostFinance · SYGNUM	●○○ COMPLETED POC
CHF Stablecoin Sandbox	Test institutional transfers, digital-asset settlement and programmable payments using CHFD. UBS · PostFinance · SYGNUM · Stablecoin AG · RAIFFEISEN · Zürcher Kantonalbank · TWINT · BCV	●○○ SANDBOX TESTING
Project Agorá	Combine tokenized commercial-bank deposits and central-bank reserves for wholesale cross-border payments. UBS · PostFinance · SYGNUM · AMINA · Basler Kantonalbank · BCV · SNB BNS	●●○ PILOT TESTING

The work extends beyond banks. SIX participates in three of these four initiatives, bringing experience from its role as a major provider of Switzerland's exchange, securities settlement and payment infrastructure. Its involvement connects the experiments with systems that banks already use. Internally, SIX has also merged its digital securities depository into SIX SIS, bringing digital and conventional securities services into the same legal entity as a foundation for more integrated post-trade services.

02

A Digital Franc Must Earn Its Place

The franc's appeal as a store of value gives a CHF stablecoin a potential audience among investors internationally. But demand for the currency alone does not provide an issuer with enough revenue to cover operating costs. For CHF issuers, finding the right business model is particularly difficult. The SNB maintained its policy rate at 0% in June 2026, limiting the attractiveness of a business model funded primarily by CHF reserve income. Our assessment is that payments, foreign exchange and complementary banking services become more important to the investment case.

Experience has been mixed, too. Bitcoin Suisse discontinued CryptoFranc in 2024. Germany-based AllUnity has since launched CHFAU alongside its other currency-backed stablecoins, illustrating how a Swiss-franc stablecoin business can emerge outside Switzerland as part of a broader model for onchain foreign exchange and payments. Frankencoin pursues a different model. ZCHF is created against collateral through a decentralized protocol rather than a fiat-reserve issuer's redemption promise, so its economics and risks require separate assessment.

Swiss banks are now exploring yet another route: a jointly developed model that combines potential distribution with shared experimentation. SIX and TWINT joined the sandbox in September, adding securities and payments expertise. The initiative should help establish where a CHF stablecoin can create tangible value before participating institutions commit to a commercial service.

03 Regulation Shapes How Far the Network Can Reach

AllUnity's entry also illustrates how the regulatory comparison has changed. The EU now provides a clearer statutory route for fiat-referenced stablecoin issuance through MiCA. Credit institutions and electronic-money institutions can issue e-money tokens subject to its requirements, including provisions governing issuance and redemption.

Swiss issuance is possible, but appears considerably more difficult. One of the main constraints lies in existing holder-identification requirements, which limit how freely tokens can circulate. Unlike under MiCA, FINMA requires appropriate identification procedures and transfer restrictions. Stengel explains what this means for network design under FINMA guidance.



> It treats the issuer's obligation towards each holder as an ongoing business relationship and consequently expects every person controlling the stablecoin to be identified by the issuer or an appropriately supervised intermediary. In practice, this leads to whitelisting or other transfer restrictions. It protects financial integrity, but it also risks turning an open payment instrument into a closed network.
>
> **Cornelia Stengel,** Kellerhals Carrard

The proposed payment-instrument institution would remove the fintech licence's CHF 100 million customer-funds ceiling, protect those funds in insolvency and permit risk-based secondary-market controls, including blacklisting. However, banks issuing the newly defined stablecoin category would need a separate entity and licence. The reform would improve the route to scale while retaining an additional organisational hurdle for banks.

04 Earlier Investment Provides a Foundation for Further Work

Clearer rules would help banks decide how to participate. They cannot determine whether customers will use a service often enough to make it worthwhile. Switzerland also starts with efficient conventional infrastructure, which raises the standard new applications must meet.



> Many traditional Swiss market infrastructures are already highly efficient. Tokenization will therefore scale only where it produces a clear economic advantage that exceeds the cost and complexity of migration.
>
> **Cornelia Stengel,** Kellerhals Carrard

For banks, that means evaluating a proposed network against actual customer flows: which counterparties must participate, what liquidity is required, and which costs or delays the new arrangement removes. Shared investment can spread development costs, but only recurring business can sustain the operating model.

Swiss banks with established digital-asset operations have relevant experience to draw on, particularly in custody, blockchain transactions and compliance. How much they can reuse will depend on the application. Payments and tokenized securities introduce further requirements around the operating model and the infrastructure's policy engines. Their earlier investment can make that work easier to undertake, while substantial development and coordination remain ahead.

INTERVIEW • ALLUNITY

AllUnity's CHFAU: The Fastest Growing CHF Stablecoin



In late February, AllUnity launched the Swiss franc-denominated CHFAU under the EU's MiCA framework. Just a few months later, it has reached 50 million francs in circulation. We spoke with **CEO Alexander Höptner.**

What led you to launch a CHF-denominated stablecoin shortly after your euro token?

We never set out to be a euro-only issuer. The goal has always been a global, multi-currency payment network, because blockchain's real efficiency gains come from cross-border payments and cross-border almost always means cross-currency. Under MiCA, our BaFin approval lets us issue in nearly any currency, so the Swiss franc was never a question of if.

What decided the timing was demand. Swiss financial institutions and corporates were the first and most vocal group to approach us with concrete interest. Before the launch, we proactively briefed FINMA on exactly what we would and would not do. And importantly, we do not actively market in Switzerland. The Swiss institutions came to us.

What types of institutions hold CHFAU today, and what are its primary use cases?

We operate a B2B2C model: two Swiss financial institutions acquire CHFAU directly from us and distribute it to their clients. We deliberately do not see who the end holders are. First buyers mint the token, and from there it moves like cash. We assume most demand today comes from holders seeking direct, regulated access to the Swiss franc as a safe-haven asset: fully cash-backed, redeemable at par, no Swiss bank account required.

Over time, we expect cross-border corporate payments to become the dominant use case; the first corporates are onboarding now. To illustrate the potential: for a multinational European corporation, we recently executed a euro transfer to Ghana, a route that traditionally takes days and costs percentages. We settled it in eight minutes at two basis points.

What business model are you building around CHFAU, given Switzerland's near-zero interest rates?

Today, all of our revenue comes from interest on reserves. For the Swiss franc that is obviously less attractive, but the model has to be judged across the full portfolio of currencies we issue, not on a single token.

The second pillar will be foreign exchange. Connected to multiple banks and liquidity providers, we achieve better FX rates than a corporate relying on a single bank. And while we cannot pass reserve interest on to holders, we can use it to lower FX costs.

As volumes grow, transaction fees of one or two basis points become conceivable. Issuance and redemption, however, will always remain free: 100 Swiss francs in, 100 CHFAU out.

No corporate we speak to has raised missing interest as a concern. Their immediate problems are FX costs and settlement times. Once a payment arrives, they can redeem within minutes and invest the proceeds. Payment efficiency comes first. Yield is the second question.

What are your growth expectations for the next 12 to 18 months?

Our partners expected CHFAU to reach around 50 million Swiss francs in circulation by mid-year, and we reached that target as planned. Crossing that threshold gave the token greater recognition and has already generated more inquiries and onboardings.

Over the next 12 to 18 months, we believe CHFAU can exceed 100 million francs, with 100 to 200 million realistic. I would not project 500 million at this stage. The outcome will depend on market conditions, broader international developments and the direction of Swiss regulation.

05

About Blockstories

Blockstories is Europe's **leading digital assets media company** focused on financial institutions.

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With our briefings and reports, we provide thousands of professionals with the critical research and analyses they need to make better decisions about digital assets.

Events

Each year, we run three big European event series on the big trends in digital assets, featuring invite-only events in cities like Zurich, London, Stockholm, Madrid, Frankfurt, Paris, Amsterdam, Barcelona and Milan. There's only one rule: Only keynotes. No panels.

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